A Recipe for a Smooth Transition

Example: Sofia, age 12

TEMPERAMENT

- Needs a Routine
- Doesn't Adjust Easily
- Retreats from New Situations
- Tends to Have Big Emotions

INSTRUCTION

This type of child does not transition well or easily. In fact, they might start reacting to the upcoming transition the night before: having a hard time sleeping, wanting to sleep in your bed, or starting a conversation right when YOU are ready to go to bed.

Consistency and routine are going to be your family's friend. Your child may need to know what is going to happen step by step, and you may have to talk about it A LOT before it happens.

You'll want to have lots of ways for them to wrap their minds around the upcoming transition. Use words, visuals and pictures where appropriate to help them prepare.

When it comes to the actual transition, have a few key phrases and a short routine:

> *Bye kiddo, I love you to the moon! Have a good time and I'll see you in X days (or on Tuesday).*



Preparing

- Lots: visual, verbal and written



Goodbye

- Same 2-3 phrases
- Remind them when you will see them next



Instead of a Message

- A heads-up note between parents the night before
- One answer from both homes

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A Recipe for a Quick Transition

Example: Diego, age 4

TEMPERAMENT

- Easily Distracted
- Constantly Wiggly

INSTRUCTION

For the kid who can't keep still and whose mind is always going, keep it short and sweet.

It will be important that you have things well organized and ready to go for your young child.

For older children, a checklist might help them stay on task while they get organized to move between houses.

Your goodbye should be brief, and a wiggly body needs somewhere to go: "Hey, buddy, your snack is waiting for you in the car. Let's get strapped in and you can pick what you want to have first."



Preparing

- Keep it short
- Lists will help



Goodbye

- "Love you!"



Instead of a Message

- A love note in the lunch box is great
- Messages for the other parent go parent to parent

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My Exchange Recipe

For | Handoff

MY HANDOFF

Time, place, noisy or calm. Why does it work well? Why does it go poorly?

TEMPERAMENT

The one or two traits this moment is running on (page 1 of your Field Notes).

INSTRUCTION

What I will say and what I will do.



Preparing



Goodbye



Instead of a Message

Read it back as if you were your child. Would it feel safe? Does it sound like you are on their side?

Hold it loosely. A recipe is a first draft. You taste it, then you adjust.

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